

seem to be a the better option—albeit at added running costs.

Extras

This is one area where the list of players just keeps on increasing. Starting with the Samsung YP-T8, which has an MPEG-4 video player, FM radio/recorder, voice recorder, photo viewer, motion sensor (for games), and yes, it also features a USB host inside the vertically oriented player! Phew, now that's what we call feature-packed! The colour screen is absolutely vibrant and videos really look good. Flaunt value? It doesn't get better than this—not yet, at least!

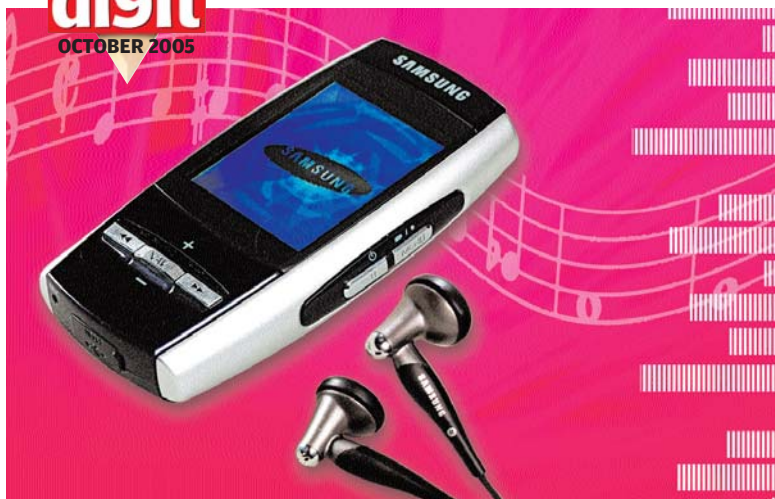
The iRivers were the only players that bundled Sennheiser earphones with their players. For the uninitiated, Sennheiser is one of the most respected manufacturers of audio equipment worldwide.

The iRiver and Samsung players also featured Line-In encoding, which lets you encode audio from another source directly to MP3 or WAV format using the player. You can convert your old tape cassettes into MP3s using these players!

Then comes the Creative Brat Pack, the brand which has the distinction of making winners instead of players. This time around, the Creative C100 was the player that stood out. It had a distinctive semi-circular shape resembling a stopwatch used in athletics. Actually, it really does have a lap-timer and stopwatch on the player! Though a little bulky, the player is still very functional, rugged and meant for users who have extended periods of outdoor activity in their lifestyle.

Another distinctive feature of this player is that it can read data from memory cards (SD/MMC) which dramatically increases the storage capacity aspect for the player—it accepts SD/MMC cards of up to 512 MB capacity. Another player to offer memory card support was the UMAX Vega203, which was a well built and rugged player.

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The Samsung YP-T8 can also play videos

The YES 910 portable player had a truly unique feature. This player can also be used as a remote control for some TVs. It makes us wonder what features next generation players will have? Lasers to open safes?

The YES 980 was a real looker, with a slide out cover that hid the controls beneath it. With an OLED display, this player was also packed with features including FM and voice recording.

On the other end of the features spectrum is the small unassuming iPod Shuffle. This player stands as an example to the adage that small is beautiful. It will appeal to those users who want a no frills portable audio player. No display, no equalisers, no radio, no nothing! Just a player with the iPod tag.

Ergonomics And Ease Of Use

The iRiver iFP-799 was one of the most rugged players we have seen thus far. Design has been given a lot of attention here, and it is targeted at men. The iRiver T20, on the other hand, is a

How We Tested

The process of testing the portable digital music players was kept very simple to enable fair judging and ensure that the scores fairly reflected the real life performance of the player.

The test system we used ran a Pentium IV 3.2 GHz on an Intel D850EMV2 motherboard with onboard sound and a GeForce2 GTS Ultra 64MB video card. Two Samsung 256 MB RDRAM memory modules provided the system memory while the all the software and the operating system was loaded on a Seagate 40 GB IDE hard drive; Windows XP Professional with Service Pack 1 (for USB 2.0 functionality) was used as the operating system used for our tests.

For the tests, we categorised the players into two distinct categories: flash based players and hard drive based players.

In the Features Test, we included all features a player could possibly have including the storage capacity, FM recording, Line-In Encoding, USB 2.0, various audio formats it supported and so on. Features that were unique to a player such as text and video support (which was available on quite a few players) were given extra points to make sure these features added up in the final Features scores.

In the Ergonomics and Ease of Use tests, we allotted the most weightage to the interface and intuitiveness of the button placement on a player. This was followed by the earphone

comfort factor that is very important if you are looking for a portable digital music player. Build quality was another criterion that we looked at since the players should be able to handle a fair amount of wear and tear.

The Performance Tests included playing selected audio files on the players and transferring data to the player. For players that supported voice or audio recording, we recorded a small paragraph at the default settings to check the recording quality.

The songs we included for testing included a heavy bass file, a flange and bass track, 'World On Fire' by Sarah McLachlan and two Hindi tracks: 'Dil Haaray Pukaray' and 'Lamhey' by Jal. Both tracks are guitar-heavy with extremely well laid out vocals.

A real world test was also conducted in which files amounting to 100 MB were transferred from the computer to the player and the time taken was recorded. In the case of micro drive and hard drive based players, we transferred 1 GB worth of music to gauge data transfer speeds.

The battery test was another important factor that all the players were made to go through. For the battery tests, we played all the songs in a loop and kept the 'Repeat All' option turned ON while the display of the player was turned ON from time to time.